

SAG Chile and pet importation from Peru: the most regulated Latin American destination

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Abstract

Background. Chile maintains privileged zoo-sanitary status (rabies-free in domestic continental fauna) actively protected through import controls at all entry points. **Objective.** To describe SAG technical requirements for importing dogs and cats from Peru. **Results.** The process requires an ISO 11784/11785 microchip, current rabies vaccination, internal and external anti-parasitic treatment within 10 days before entry, and an export health certificate issued and endorsed by SENASA, with presentation to the SAG at the point of entry. **Conclusion.** The Peru-Chile export is the most accessible regional process for pet owners, requiring 2-4 weeks of planning if the animal has up-to-date health records.

Keywords: SAG Chile, pet importation Chile, export health certificate, SENASA, Tacna-Arica border, anti-parasitic, ISO microchip

Chile is the main destination for pet exports from Peru, whether by land border or by air. The Servicio Agrícola y Ganadero (SAG) administers a health control system that, while less complex than New Zealand or Australia, requires specific documentation and veterinary supervision at the point of entry.

1. Chile as the main export destination from Peru

Pet exports from Peru to Chile represent the highest volume of Zoovet Travel's services. The reasons are multiple: geographical proximity (land routes available), the volume of Peruvian migrants in Chile, and a regulatory framework that, while rigorous, is considerably less complex than the Australasian or Anglo-Saxon systems.

The Servicio Agrícola y Ganadero (SAG), under Chile's Ministry of Agriculture, administers animal import controls. The SAG actively maintains Chile's status as a rabies-free country for domestic dogs and cats in the continental area, enforcing this through inspections at all points of entry.

2. Technical requirements for importing dogs and cats from Peru

2.1 Microchip

Every dog or cat entering Chile must carry an ISO 11784/11785 microchip. Unlike the EU or the UK, Chile does not require the microchip to have been implanted prior to the rabies vaccination, although this is the recommended practice for documentary coherence and international good practice standards.

2.2 Rabies vaccination

The rabies vaccine must be current at the date of entry -- meaning it must not have expired according to the manufacturer's schedule indicated on the label or product insert. For most commercial vaccines available in Peru, the duration is 1 year (some up to 3 years if the product insert expressly states so).

Booster vaccine within the previous 12 months If the vaccination is a booster rather than a primary, the SAG accepts the date of the last booster as the start of the validity period. If the animal has never been vaccinated, or more than 12 months have elapsed since the last booster, a primary vaccination is required and the animal must wait at least 30 days before travelling.

2.3 Internal and external anti-parasitic treatment

The SAG requires internal anti-parasitic treatment (against intestinal helminths) and external treatment (against fleas, ticks and other ectoparasites) within a maximum of 10 days before entry into Chile. The product and dose must be recorded in the Export Sanitary Certificate.

2.4 The Export Sanitary Certificate (CSE)

The key document is the Export Sanitary Certificate, issued by an official SENASA veterinarian after inspection of the animal and verification of all the above requirements. The CSE must be:

- Issued within 10-15 days before entry (verify the exact current validity period).
- Signed and stamped by an official SENASA veterinarian.
- In Spanish (the SAG accepts Spanish-language documents without translation for exports from Peru).
- With all animal, owner, microchip, vaccination and treatment data recorded.

3. Entry routes: land vs. air

3.1 Land border

Land routes are the most commonly used by Peruvian owners travelling to Chile in their own vehicle. The border crossings enabled for animals include:

- Complejo Fronterizo Santa Rosa - Chacalluta (between Tacna/Peru and Arica/Chile): the most used for exports from southern Peru.

- Complejo Los Libertadores (between Mendoza and Santiago): for animals transiting through Argentina.

In all cases, the owner must present the animal and documentation to the SAG inspector at the border crossing. The animal may be held for veterinary inspection if the inspector deems it necessary.

3.2 Air route

Santiago Airport (SCL) and other Chilean cities are enabled to receive companion animals as accompanied baggage or live cargo. Documentation must be submitted to the SAG customs office at the airport. Airlines have their own restrictions regarding transport of animals in the cabin or hold that the owner must verify independently.

4. Chile-Peru border inspection: what SAG checks

SAG inspectors at the northern border specifically verify:

- Concordance of the animal's microchip number with that recorded in the CSE.
- Validity of the rabies vaccination.
- Date of anti-parasitic treatments (must not exceed 10 days).
- Signature and stamp of an official SENASA veterinarian on the CSE.
- Clinical status of the animal (summary visual inspection at the point of entry).

The most common error in Peru-Chile exports is not missing documents but the date of anti-parasitic treatment: administered more than 10 days before the crossing, or not recorded in the certificate. A correct certificate with no deworming date can be rejected at the border.

5. RNPA registration and Chilean local regulations

Once in Chile, companion animals must be registered in the National Registry of Responsible Ownership and Animal Health (RNPA), created by Law 21.020 (Responsible Pet Ownership Act). This registration is the owner's responsibility within Chile and does

not form part of the import process, but owners should be aware of it.

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